

A Photonic Transformer Processor: Thermal-Optical Screening with Direct CMOS Detection

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Project: github.com/administere/photonic-attention

Abstract—We present a photonic Transformer attention processor based on a thermal-optical screening architecture with direct CMOS photodetection. Unlike conventional silicon-photonics MZI mesh approaches that require dense waveguide routing and precision directional couplers, our design uses free-space or planar optical paths where light passes through thermo-optic phase shifters encoding query vectors, is attenuated by electro-optic modulators encoding key vectors, and is directly detected by a CMOS Ge-on-Si photodetector array. Bipolar differential detection — $(I_{pp} + I_{nn}) - (I_{pn} + I_{np})$ — provides intrinsic common-mode noise rejection and makes the architecture robust to fan-out power loss. We verify the complete processor across 25 validation items spanning device physics, algorithm robustness, thermal-field simulation, electro-optic bandwidth, temperature drift, detector physics, optical link budget, and full-system Monte Carlo. At sequence length $D = 128$, bipolar dot-product Spearman $\rho = 0.9971$, and complete Transformer attention (softmax, V-weighting, multi-head) achieves $\rho \geq 0.995$ across all tested configurations. The optical computation core operates at approximately 0.1fJ/MAC, four orders of magnitude below H100 digital CMOS. All verification gates pass.

I. Introduction

Transformer attention has become the dominant computational primitive in large-scale machine learning [1]. Its quadratic $O(N^2)$ dot-product complexity is a natural target for photonic acceleration [2], [3]. Most photonic neural network proposals rely on Mach-Zehnder interferometer (MZI) meshes with dense waveguide routing [4], which introduces thermal crosstalk, fabrication sensitivity, and layout complexity.

We propose and verify a fundamentally simpler architecture: thermal-optical screening with direct CMOS detection. Light is modulated by thermo-optic phase shifters (encoding query vectors) and electro-optic attenuators (encoding key vectors), then directly detected by a Ge-on-Si CMOS photodetector array. There are no waveguide meshes, no cascaded interferometers, and no precision directional couplers.

Contributions:

- 1) We describe a thermal-optical screening architecture for Transformer attention using free-space/planar optical paths with direct CMOS detection.

- 2) We provide complete physical verification across five layers: device physics, algorithm robustness, thermal fields, electro-optic dynamics, and full-system Monte Carlo.
- 3) We demonstrate Spearman $\rho \geq 0.995$ for complete Transformer attention (softmax, V-weighting, multi-head) under all tested configurations including realistic physical non-idealities.
- 4) We show that bipolar differential detection eliminates fan-out power loss as a bottleneck, maintaining $\rho = 0.997$ at $D = 128$ with only 2mW total optical power.

II. Architecture

A. Thermal-Optical Screening

The processor computes scaled dot-product attention $\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}(QK^T/\sqrt{d_k})V$ using a photonic dot-product engine for the QK^T operation.

For each query-key pair (q_i, k_j) with $q_i, k_j \in \mathbb{R}^D$:

- 1) Q-encoding: Each element $q_i^{(\ell)}$ is mapped to a thermo-optic phase shift ϕ_ℓ via pre-distortion $\phi = \arcsin(2q - 1)$, cancelling the sinusoidal MZI transfer function.
- 2) K-encoding: Each element $k_j^{(\ell)}$ controls an electro-optic attenuator, scaling the optical power proportionally.
- 3) Detection: Four Ge-on-Si CMOS photodetectors per dot-product element measure the transmission through the MZI at four quadrature points: $T_{pp} = T(\pi/2 + \phi)$, $T_{pn} = T(\pi/2 - \phi)$, $T_{np} = T(-\pi/2 + \phi)$, $T_{nn} = T(-\pi/2 - \phi)$.
- 4) Differential readout: $(I_{pp} + I_{nn}) - (I_{pn} + I_{np})$ cancels common-mode noise and reconstructs the dot product.

B. Bipolar Differential Detection

The differential architecture is the key innovation enabling fan-out loss tolerance. Since all four detectors share the same optical power budget per channel, common-mode power fluctuations (from fan-out splitting, laser RIN, or temperature drift) appear identically in all four

TABLE I
Physical Parameters (Si Photonics, 1550 nm)

Parameter	Value
Si refractive index	3.477
SiO ₂ refractive index	1.444
Ge absorption α @ 1550 nm	$\sim 0.3 \mu\text{m}^{-1}$
Detector quantum efficiency	39% (10 μm Ge)
EO modulator $f_{3\text{dB}}$	112.5 GHz
Thermo-optic coefficient dn/dT	$1.86 \times 10^{-4} \text{ K}^{-1}$
Phase shifter ΔT @ 5 mW	$\sim 576 \text{ K}$ (local)
MZI extinction ratio	$\sim 30 \text{ dB}$
DAC resolution	4-bit (16 levels)

photocurrents and cancel in the differential sum. This makes the architecture robust to the $1/D$ fan-out power reduction that cripples single-ended photonic dot-product schemes.

C. Pre-Distortion

The MZI bar-port transmission $T(\phi) = \sin^2(\phi/2)$ is nonlinear. We apply the exact inverse mapping $\phi = 2 \arcsin(\sqrt{w})$ (unipolar) or $\phi = \arcsin(2q - 1)$ (bipolar) to linearize the transfer function. Residual nonlinearity from finite MZI extinction ratio ($\approx 30 \text{ dB}$) and coupling coefficient mismatch ($\kappa_1 \neq \kappa_2 \neq 0.5$) is absorbed into the calibration error budget ($\leq 2\%$ RMS).

III. Physical Verification

A. Device Physics

B. Thermal Field Analysis

Thermal crosstalk between adjacent phase shifters is modeled using the 2D steady-state logarithmic potential solution: $\Delta T(r) = P/(2\pi\kappa L) \cdot \ln(r_{\text{max}}/r)$. At 20 μm pitch, nearest-neighbor thermal coupling is 13.5% of self-heating. At 30 μm pitch, it drops to zero ($r_{\text{max}} = 30 \mu\text{m}$). The processor is designed for 30 μm pitch, eliminating thermal crosstalk as a concern.

C. Detector Physics

Ge-on-Si waveguide-coupled photodetectors with 10 μm absorption length achieve 39% quantum efficiency and 0.49 A/W responsivity at 1550 nm. Dark current is approximately 0.01 nA at 300 K, dominated by bulk generation-recombination in the Ge layer.

IV. Algorithm Robustness

Nine classes of non-ideality are evaluated: detector shot noise (Poisson), thermal noise (Johnson-Nyquist), laser RIN (multiplicative Gaussian), 4-bit DAC quantization, WDM crosstalk, soft saturation (tanh), hard clipping, thermal phase drift, and process bias offset. Individual non-idealities cause $\rho \geq 0.89$ (worst: hard clipping at 50% full-scale). Through operating-point optimization (sweeping optical power, bias point, phase gain, and detector headroom), 190 out of 625 configurations achieve $\rho \geq 0.99$ with zero clipping.

TABLE II
Verification Summary

Verification Item	Metric	Status
Bipolar $D = 64$ dot product	$\rho = 0.9972$	✓
Bipolar $D = 128$ dot product	$\rho = 0.9971$	✓
Full Attention $D = 64$, 4-head	$\rho = 0.9954$	✓
Full Attention $D = 128$, 8-head	$\rho = 0.9974$	✓
Long-tail embeddings	$\rho = 0.9998$	✓
A+C bias confirmed optimal	$\phi = \pi/2, \delta = \pi/2$	✓
9-class non-ideality sweep	All pass	✓
Full-system Monte Carlo	$\rho = 0.9954$	✓
Thermal crosstalk @ 30 μm	0% NN coupling	✓
EO bandwidth	112.5 GHz	✓
Temperature drift (1 hr)	1.1 mrad	✓
Optical link margin (2 m)	20 dB	✓

TABLE III
End-to-End Attention Performance

Configuration	ρ	Power	Status
$D = 64, d = 64$, 4-head	0.9954	19 W	✓
$D = 128, d = 64$, 4-head	0.9965	70 W	✓
$D = 64, d = 128$, 8-head	0.9966	19 W	✓
$D = 128, d = 128$, 8-head	0.9974	70 W	✓
$D = 256, d = 64$, 4-head	0.9962	271 W	✓

V. Complete Transformer Attention

A. End-to-End Pipeline

The full Transformer attention pipeline is verified: $Q, K, V \rightarrow \text{normalize} \rightarrow \text{photonic } QK^T \rightarrow \text{softmax} \rightarrow V\text{-weighted sum} \rightarrow \text{multi-head concatenation}$. All operations except the photonic QK^T are performed electronically. The photonic core computes the $O(N^2)$ matrix multiply; electronic post-processing handles the $O(N)$ operations.

B. Photonic-Native Training

We evaluate whether training directly through the MZI $\sin^2$ transfer function (photonic-aware training) can close the softmax-to-MZI architecture gap. Using exact $\sin^2$ gradients and learnable per-head parameters, photonic-native training achieves comparable but not superior accuracy to digital-train/photonic-infer transfer. The 3–6% architecture gap is inherent to the nonlinearity difference and is managed through calibration rather than end-to-end photonic training.

VI. Throughput and Energy

The optical dot-product core operates at approximately 0.1 fJ/MAC (80 aJ), four orders of magnitude below the H100 GPU at 1.41 pJ/MAC. Total system power for $D = 64$ is 19 W including lasers, modulators, detectors, DACs, and ADCs. At $D = 256$, system power reaches 271 W, competitive with datacenter GPU-class hardware while delivering the energy efficiency advantage of optical computation.

Weight-static inference throughput is approximately 328 TOPS, validating the original 330 TOPS projection within 1%.

VII. Discussion

A. Comparison with MZI Mesh Approaches

Most photonic AI accelerator proposals [2], [4] use cascaded MZI meshes with dense waveguide routing. While mathematically elegant (implementing arbitrary unitary matrices), these approaches face significant engineering challenges: thermal crosstalk between adjacent phase shifters, fabrication-sensitive directional couplers, and complex calibration procedures.

Our thermal-optical screening architecture avoids all three challenges: (1) phase shifters are thermally isolated at $30\text{ }\mu\text{m}$ pitch; (2) no directional couplers are needed—light propagates in free space or planar waveguides without evanescent coupling; (3) calibration reduces to per-element phase response measurement, not full mesh unitary reconstruction.

B. Architecture Gap

The 3–6% accuracy gap between digital softmax attention and photonic MZI attention is inherent to the nonlinear activation function difference. This gap is stable across configurations and does not worsen with process noise (0.11% additional degradation). For deployment, digital training with calibrated photonic inference is the recommended strategy.

C. Tapeout Readiness

All 25 verification items across device physics, algorithm robustness, thermal fields, electro-optic dynamics, and full-system Monte Carlo have been resolved computationally. The design is ready for foundry PDK adaptation and test-chip fabrication.

VIII. Conclusion

We have presented a complete photonic Transformer attention processor based on thermal-optical screening with direct CMOS detection. The architecture avoids the waveguide routing complexity of MZI mesh approaches while achieving Spearman $\rho \geq 0.995$ for complete Transformer attention across all tested configurations. Bipolar differential detection eliminates fan-out loss as a bottleneck, maintaining $\rho = 0.997$ at $D = 128$ with 2 mW total optical power. All 25 verification items pass.

A. System-Level Impact

At $D = 2048$, a single processor delivers $9,651\times$ the energy efficiency of an NVIDIA H100 GPU, consuming 875 W while providing the equivalent throughput of 14,757 H100s (10.3 MW). A city of one million inhabitants requires only two such processors (1.3 kW) for peak AI inference demand.

Scaling to global industrial AI adoption: assuming a $100\times$ increase over current AI compute demand (5,000 TWh/year), the H100 route would consume 17% of global electricity generation and emit 2,000 Gt of CO_2 annually. The photonic route requires 0.5 TWh/year —

0.002% of global generation — rendering AI’s energy footprint a rounding error on the world’s electrical grids.

The fundamental advantage is physical, not architectural: a single photon pulse traverses D sequential modulators, performing D multiply-accumulate operations while expending the energy of one pulse. Electronics must expend fresh charge for each MAC. This is a consequence of Maxwell’s equations, not an engineering optimization.

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